Is SAFe a product operating model, Really?

- SAFe is the de facto standard for delivery at scale.
- Leaders still ask: "And now what?"
- This talk is not challenging SAFe, it complements it to cover the full product journey.

Mylene El-Kaim, Amadeus

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Mylene El-Kaim

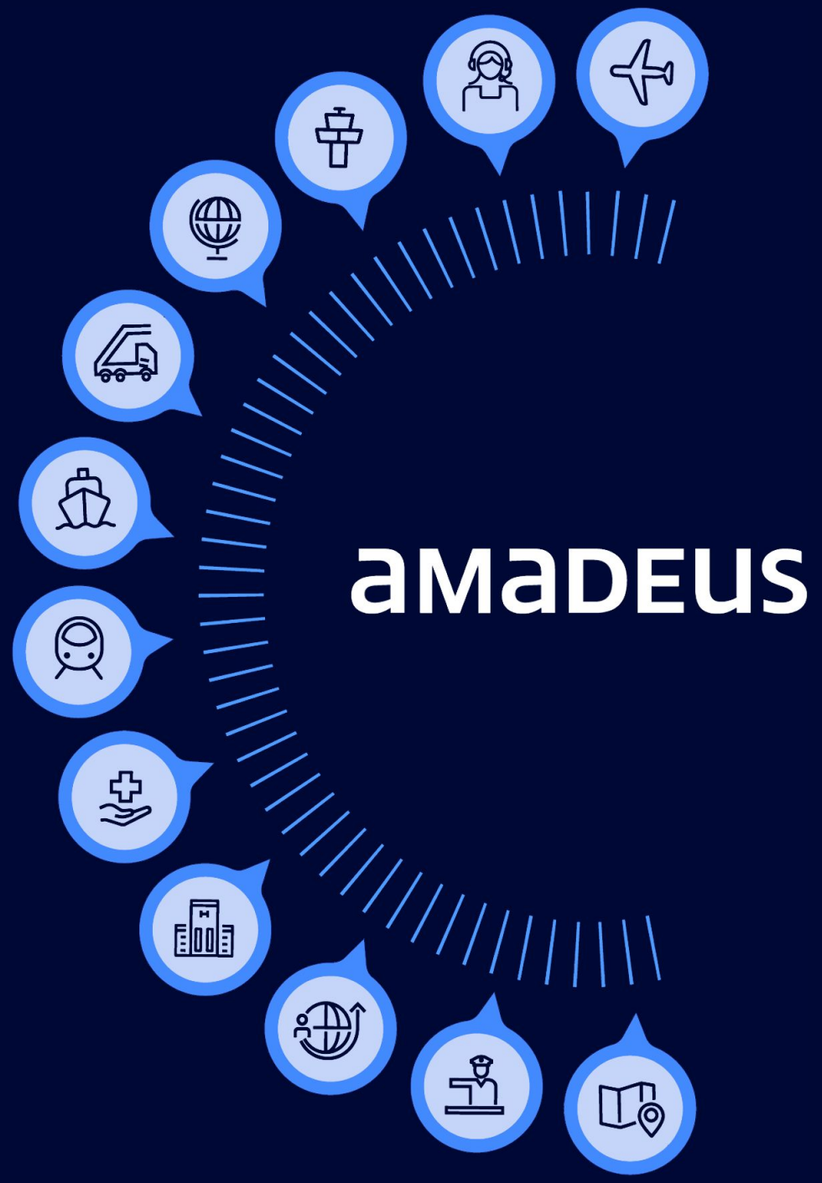
Head of Amadeus Lean-Agile Center of Excellence

iSPCT Candidate

Amadeus

Amadeus is a technology company dedicated to the world's travel industry

- Airlines
- Travel agencies
- Tour operators
- Cruise and ferry lines
- Insurance providers
- Border authorities
- Airport operators
- Ground handlers
- Rail operators
- Mobility providers
- Hotel properties
- Destinations



Strategic

Microsoft
Google
accenture
IBM
tcs TATA CONSULTANCY SERVICES

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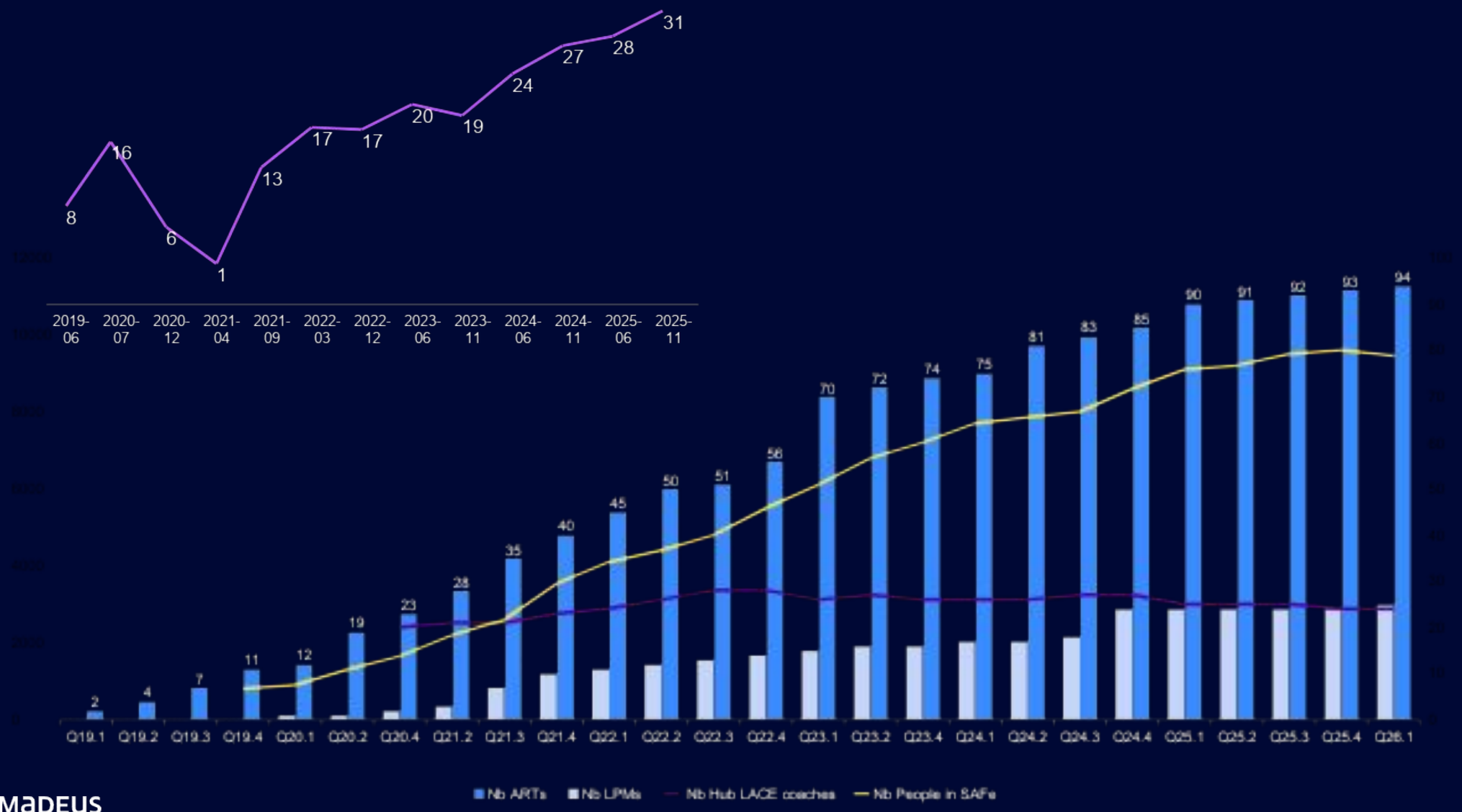
Amadeus SAFe Deployment Evolution

11 Mar 26



94 Agile Release Trains

9,400+ people in SAFe

95% of Engineering Community

25 Lean Portfolios

6 Large Solutions

15 ARTs in Lean Time Reporting

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Is SAFe a Product operating model, really?

Why does this matter?

Without a full Product Operating Model, execution in delivery is strong, but **product outcomes** are inconsistent.

Discover > **Strategy** > **Delivery** > **Market Place**

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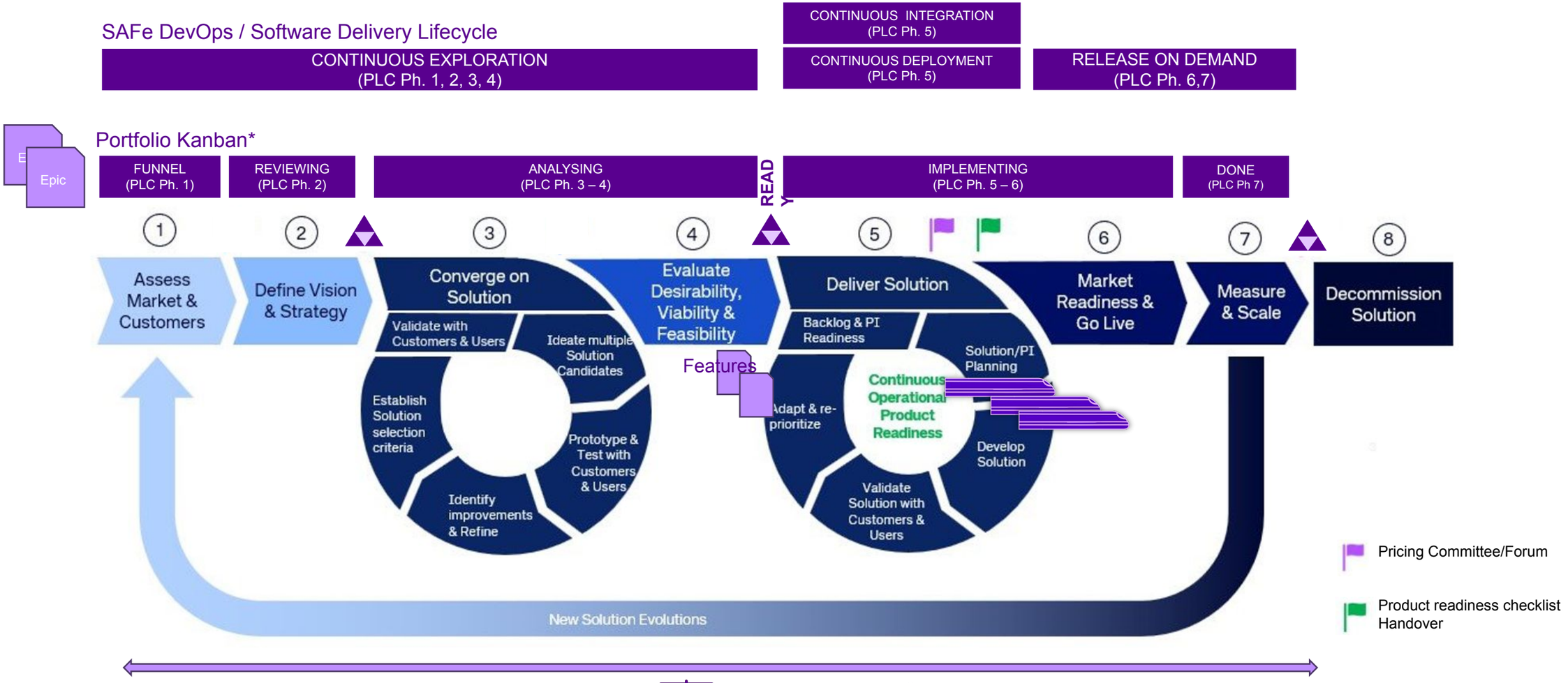
PLC and SAFe : One Value Flow



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* The PLC definition and acceptance criteria applies

Upstream

Continuous Discovery, integrated into SAFe

- Discovery is funded, structured, and continuous
- Before PI Planning, every initiative is validated through:
  - Customer Problems
  - Market Dynamics
  - Internal Strategy
- Multi-channel Voice of the Customer
- Design Sprints funded inside PIs

Outcome: Delivery starts from validated opportunities, not assumptions

Midstream

Clarifying Roles across the Product lifecycle

- One clear **accountability** model across the Product Lifecycle
- Product Manager **accountable end-to-end**, de facto **Epic Owner**
- Core **product team** clearly defined:
  - PM, PMM, UX, Tech Lead
- SAFe extended **beyond the ART**
  - Commercial, CX, Platform, Partnership…
- Shared decision frameworks:
  - Build / Buy / Partner
  - Platform-first

Outcome: Clear ownership, smoother collaboration, SAFe operating inside a coherent product operating model

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Downstream

Product Marketing & Go-to-Market at scale

Product Marketing = bridge from product to market

1. Clear Positioning & Messaging
2. Pricing and Commercial Strategy
3. Sales enablement at scale
4. Orchestrated Go-to-Market

Outcome: From delivery to adoption, consistently and globally.

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Throughout: AI Empowered Product team across the PLC

Faster insights from signals to structured product decisions

AI Augmented
Product management
enabling faster movement from signals to structured strategy.

- Synthesizing customer insights,
- Structuring opportunity spaces
- Competitive analysis
- Epic Drafting
- Scenario exploration for Build / Buy / Partner

AI-Driven
Engineering Efficiency
improving engineering velocity and reducing delivery friction.

- AI-assisted coding
- Test generation and automation
- Code review …

AI-Enabled
Product Marketing
allowing to respond more quickly to market signals.

- Analysis, messaging and positioning support
- Sales enablement content generation
- Go-to-market preparation

AI-Enhanced
UX & Discovery
scaling research and design exploration more efficiently.

- Research synthesis from interviews and usability studies
- Persona and journey analysis,
- Rapid prototyping, and heuristic evaluations…

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What we expect to change

Shift conversation from delivery to outcomes

- Reduced **cycle time** from opportunity to PI commitment
- Increased % PI objectives with **validated problem/insights**
- **Forecast** accuracy
- Predictable **time to market and adoption**
- **Value realization tracked post launch**

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Answering the Question

Is SAFe a Product Operating Model?
Not alone.

But extend it upstream, midstream & downstream, and embed it in cadence → Yes, it becomes one.

Let's continue the discussion during the Summit.

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Thank You